Look at my tree house 12a

All in an ant's day – a narrative

There once lived a small colony of ants in a nice comfortable nest under the ground, hidden by the leaf litter of a big gum tree. They were always a busy group going on with their day-to-day business in an orderly manner. Like any other day, this day the ants started by receiving a message, a signal giving them the location of a new stash of food. Many juicy mites had been located high up in their big eucalyptus tree extracting nourishing sap from new leaves. Quickly the ants made their way out of the nest and up along the trunk of the tree.

Along their journey they met several insect borers munching away on some bark. A stick insect curiously moved towards the ants but suddenly stopped. It camouflaged itself on the bark of the tree by staying very still, so it looked like a leafless branch. The surprised ants suddenly understood why the stick insect interrupted its journey when a magpie swooped down and snatched the stick insect for its breakfast. There was not much the ants could do but to continue their journey, wondering whether the stick insect had enjoyed a last meal of fresh leaves.

Continuing their expedition, the ants noticed a young possum enjoying the sweet taste of the tree blossoms. But the possum was rudely interrupted by a cat climbing up towards the branches, hoping to score a possum meal! The possum hurried off, scaring the magpie away from its nest, leaving her young chicks to the fate of the cat or the tree snake that lay absolutely still amongst the branches. 'What an advantage it is being tiny,' thought the ants as they continued to scurry along their path.

It wasn't long till they reached the juicy but clumsy mites. The ants skilfully surrounded the mites and together in their gangs started to carry the mites down the tree. 'Such strength and determination!' thought a flying fox, hanging upside down enjoying the fruits of the tree. It didn't take long for a wagtail bird to notice the colourful mites being hauled down the tree and it flew near the ants to investigate. 'What a great meal!', and with its sharp beak the bird grabbed and swallowed about three mites, along with the ants that had held them. The rest of the ants took one more look at the incoming beak and decided to get out in a hurry – even if that meant losing the mites. Tired and hungry, the surviving ants made their way down the tree towards their nest, only to find it was blocked by some droppings from the flying fox.

The ants retreated into the bark of the tree, where the borers had been previously, to shield themselves from the cold evening. Watching their nest from the safety of the tree and hoping the dung beetles would hurry up and eat the droppings before it got too dark, the ants saw an echidna making its way towards their nest. It all happened so frighteningly fast: the echidna found their nest, pushed its snout into the nest and with its long sticky tongue scooped up every last ant. The ants in the tree could not help but think how lucky they were this time and resolved never to complain again about another flying fox or its droppings! They set off together to start another colony under another tree.

1 Use the narrative to construct a food web with Diagram 1 on the next page. Cut out the animals mentioned in the story and paste them in the correct position on the tree house. Join the animals by arrows according to their eating patterns.

2 Look at your food web and list the:

a producers _____

b first order consumers _____

c second order consumers _____

3 Construct three food chains from the food web.

_____

_____

_____

4 Predict what would happen if all the birds living in the tree were killed by the cat.

_____

_____

_____

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Look at my tree house 12b

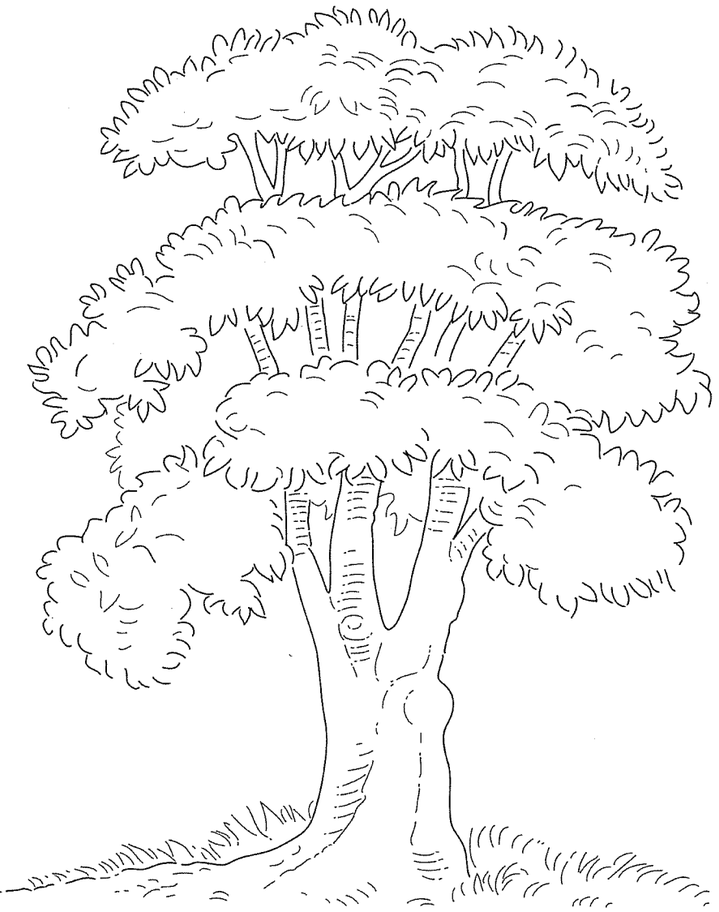
5 **a** Connect these food chains into a food web.

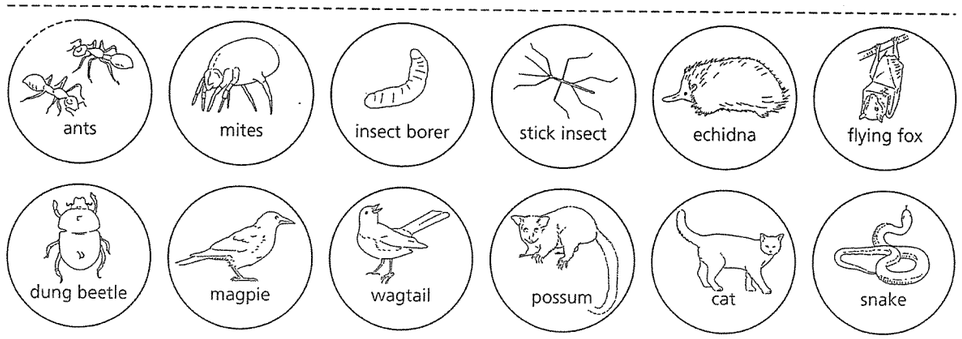
Algae → tadpole→ small fish → duck

Pondweed → snail → frog → kookaburra

b Write your own narrative using your food web.

Diagram 1





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